Skill Radar

THE COMPLETE

CLAUDE AI GUIDE

From First Chat to Full AI Workspace

Everything you need to master Claude — research, reasoning, coding, automation, files, dashboards, and beyond.

1. What Is Claude?

Claude is an AI assistant made by Anthropic. But calling it just a "chatbot" undersells it. Claude is a full AI workspace — capable of intelligent conversation, deep research, multi-step reasoning, code generation, file processing, document creation, and workflow automation.

Think of Claude as the colleague who never sleeps, never gets frustrated, reads everything you send in seconds, and gives you structured, thoughtful output — every single time.

Claude vs. Other AI Tools

Feature	What Claude Offers
Conversation	Natural, context-aware dialogue across long sessions
Reasoning	Step-by-step thinking for complex decisions
Research & Analysis	Synthesizes information, finds patterns, draws insights
Code	Writes, debugs, and explains code in 20+ languages
File Handling	Reads PDFs, CSVs, images, Word docs — and acts on them
Document Creation	Generates reports, decks, dashboards inside chat
Automation	Builds workflows that process your data end-to-end
API Access	Full product development with no UI restrictions

KEY INSIGHT Claude is not a search engine. It doesn't just retrieve — it thinks, writes, builds, and automates.

2. Getting Started

How to Access Claude

Claude.ai (Web & App)

- Visit claude.ai — free tier available, no credit card needed
- Available on web browser, iOS app, and Android app
- Supports file uploads, image inputs, and long conversations

Claude API (For Developers)

- Access at console.anthropic.com
- Build full products on top of Claude
- Integrate into your own apps, workflows, and pipelines
- Current models: Claude Opus 4.6, Sonnet 4.6, Haiku 4.5

Claude Code (For Developers)

- A command-line tool for agentic coding tasks
- Claude can read your codebase, write files, run tests, and iterate
- Install via npm and run directly in your terminal

Specialized Integrations

- Claude in Chrome — browser agent for web automation
- Claude in Excel / PowerPoint — work with spreadsheets and slides
- Claude Code for VS Code and JetBrains — IDE-native AI coding

Your First Conversation

Getting value from Claude starts with how you communicate. Unlike traditional search, Claude understands intent, context, and nuance. Here is how to begin effectively:

1. Be specific about what you want — vague prompts give vague answers
2. Provide context — tell Claude who you are and what you are trying to achieve

3. Specify the format — ask for bullet points, a table, a step-by-step plan, or a paragraph
4. Iterate — refine your prompt based on the response you get

3. Core Capabilities

A. Intelligent Conversation

Claude maintains context across an entire conversation. You can ask follow-up questions, refer to what was said earlier, and build on previous answers — like talking to a knowledgeable colleague.

- Ask open-ended questions and get structured answers
- Explore ideas through back-and-forth dialogue
- Request Claude to explain its reasoning at any step
- Switch topics naturally — Claude adapts mid-conversation

B. Research & Analysis

Claude excels at synthesizing information, identifying patterns, and turning raw data into actionable insights. Provide Claude with text, data, or documents, and it will analyze them for you.

What You Can Do

- Summarize long documents, reports, or articles
- Compare multiple options side-by-side (tools, strategies, vendors)
- Extract key insights from research papers or meeting notes
- Identify gaps, risks, or inconsistencies in plans
- Build competitive analyses or market overviews

EXAMPLE Paste in a 10-page contract and ask: 'Summarize the key obligations, red flags, and payment terms in bullet points.'

C. Step-by-Step Reasoning

For complex decisions, Claude can think through problems methodically before giving you an answer. This is its reasoning capability — ideal for anything where logic, trade-offs, and consequences matter.

Best Use Cases

- Technical architecture decisions
- Business strategy evaluation
- Legal or financial scenario analysis (always verify with a professional)
- Root cause analysis and debugging
- Exam-style reasoning, logic puzzles, and proofs

TRY THIS Ask Claude: 'Think step by step — should I build this feature in-house or outsource it? Consider cost, speed, quality, and long-term maintainability.'

D. Writing & Content Creation

Claude is a professional-grade writing partner. It adapts its tone, format, and style to your needs — whether you need a casual blog post or a formal board memo.

Content Type	What Claude Can Write
Business Docs	Reports, proposals, memos, executive summaries
Marketing	Ad copy, email campaigns, landing page text, taglines
Technical Writing	API docs, user guides, README files, changelogs
Creative	Short stories, scripts, social media posts, newsletters
Academic	Essays, literature reviews, research outlines (drafting aid)
Communication	Emails, Slack messages, meeting agendas, slide outlines

E. Coding & Development

Claude is one of the strongest AI coding assistants available. It understands architecture, not just syntax — meaning it can help you design systems, not just write functions.

Languages & Frameworks

- Python, JavaScript/TypeScript, Java, C/C++, Go, Rust, SQL, and more
- React, Node.js, Django, FastAPI, Next.js, and major frameworks
- Shell scripting, Docker, Kubernetes, and DevOps tooling

What Claude Can Do With Code

- Write new functions, classes, or entire modules from a description
- Debug errors — paste in the error and relevant code
- Explain unfamiliar code line by line
- Refactor messy code for clarity, performance, or best practices
- Write tests and suggest edge cases
- Review pull requests and suggest improvements

TIP For large codebases, use Claude Code (CLI tool) — it reads your entire repo and works with the full context of your project.

4. Working With Files & Documents

One of Claude's most powerful features is its ability to read, process, and act on files — directly inside chat. No external tools required.

Supported File Types

File Type	What Claude Can Do
PDF	Extract text, summarize, answer questions, find specific clauses
CSV / Excel	Analyze data, identify trends, write formulas, suggest visualizations

File Type	What Claude Can Do
Word (.docx)	Read, edit, rewrite, reformat, or summarize documents
Images (PNG/JPG)	Describe, analyze, extract text (OCR), interpret charts/diagrams
Code Files	Review, debug, explain, or refactor entire files
Text Files	Process logs, configs, or any plaintext content

How to Use Files Effectively

5. Upload the file directly in the Claude.ai chat interface
6. Give Claude a clear instruction: 'Summarize this report' or 'Find all dates mentioned in this contract'
7. Follow up — ask Claude to go deeper on specific sections
8. Ask Claude to reformat, rewrite, or export the content

REAL-WORLD USE Upload your company's 50-page strategy document and ask: 'What are the 5 biggest risks mentioned? Create an action plan table for each.'

5. Building Tools & Dashboards

Claude can build functional tools inside chat — from interactive calculators to dashboards to complete web apps. You describe what you want; Claude writes the code and renders it.

What You Can Build

- Interactive dashboards with real-time controls
- Data visualization charts (bar, line, pie, scatter plots)
- Form-based tools (calculators, generators, validators)
- Simple games and simulations

- Prototype web pages (HTML, CSS, JavaScript)
- React components and full front-end UIs
- Automation scripts that process your files

Example Builds

Business Calculator

'Build me a pricing calculator with sliders for number of users, storage, and support tier. Show the monthly cost dynamically.'

Data Dashboard

'Here is a CSV with our monthly sales. Build a bar chart showing revenue by region and a table with top 10 products.'

Automation Script

'Write a Python script that reads this folder of invoices, extracts the total amount and date from each PDF, and saves everything to a spreadsheet.'

🔧 **FOR DEVELOPERS** Use the Claude API to embed this capability directly in your product. Claude becomes your AI layer — reasoning, writing, building — inside your own app.

6. API & Product Development

For developers, Claude is a foundation for building AI-powered products — not just a chat interface. The Claude API gives you programmatic access to the full model.

Getting Started With the API

1. Create an account at console.anthropic.com
2. Generate an API key from the dashboard
3. Install the Anthropic SDK: npm install @anthropic-ai/sdk or pip install anthropic
4. Send your first message programmatically

Available Models

Model	Best For
Claude Opus 4.6	Most capable — complex reasoning, nuanced tasks, deep analysis
Claude Sonnet 4.6	Balanced — fast, smart, cost-efficient for most use cases
Claude Haiku 4.5	Fastest and most affordable — high-volume, lightweight tasks

What You Can Build With the API

- Customer support bots with deep product knowledge
- Document processing pipelines (read, extract, classify, summarize)
- AI-powered internal tools (search, Q&A over your data)
- Code review and generation tools integrated in your IDE or CI/CD
- Personalized content generation at scale
- Multi-step AI agents that perform complex workflows autonomously

🚀 **BEST PRACTICE** Start with Claude Sonnet 4.6 for most applications — it offers an excellent balance of capability and speed. Move to Opus only for tasks requiring the deepest reasoning.

7. Prompting — The Master Skill

The quality of your output depends heavily on the quality of your input. Prompting is a skill — and mastering it is the single biggest lever for getting more from Claude.

The Five Pillars of a Great Prompt

1. Role / Context

Tell Claude who it is or who you are. This sets the tone, expertise level, and style of the response.

Example You are a senior product manager reviewing a feature spec. Give feedback on gaps and edge cases.

2. Task

Be specific about exactly what you want. Verbs like summarize, compare, generate, rewrite, analyze, debug, and explain are your friends.

3. Format

Specify how you want the output: bullet points, a table, a numbered list, a paragraph, a JSON object, or a code block.

4. Constraints

Add limits: word count, tone (formal/casual), audience (expert/beginner), language, or any restrictions.

5. Examples

Show Claude what a good output looks like. Few-shot examples are one of the most powerful prompting techniques available.

Prompt Patterns

Pattern	When to Use It
'Think step by step'	Complex reasoning, math, logic, analysis
'Give me 3 options'	Decision-making, creative exploration
'Act as [role]'	Setting expertise level or domain context
'Here's an example of what I want: ...'	Guiding format and style precisely
'Critique this, then improve it'	Iterative content refinement
'What am I missing?'	Gap analysis on plans, docs, or arguments

Pattern	When to Use It
'Explain like I'm 10 / like an expert'	Adjusting technical depth